

Anderson 1983 RG Notes

Anderson, Benedict. *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism*.
New York: Verso, 1983.

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- Nations are inherently “imagined” or otherwise products of conception rather than explicit lines: most members of a nation will never meet most of the other members, but still a sense of commonality exists. The nation must be limited, sovereign, and considered as a community; these align with four portions of the definition of the nation:
 1. Imagined (not the same as fake – just that it cannot be readily conceived in its entirety as a face-to-face community would)
 2. Limited / Exclusive
 3. sovereign
 4. Exists as a community
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3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- Nationalism exists on a separate dimension from fascism, liberalism, etc. – emerged from the decline of a religious / dynastic justification for peoplehood that declined in the Enlightenment period and continued thereafter
- A great deal of nation-building was facilitated by the development of effective communication technology (i.e. printing press) and capitalistic markets, which facilitated exchange particularly by means of standardized (and particularized) language
- Colonial empires developed strategic nationalistic characteristics primarily to protect dynastic and aristocracies by creating a common vision of peoplehood

- Origins largely from Latin American Creole cultures
- Three primary institutions which supported this construction particularly within colonial societies:
 1. Censuses: allowed for distinct, mutually exclusive counts and categorizations
 2. Maps: allowed for distinct borders and the creation of commonly understood delineations
 3. Museums: display of stories of peoplehood and the origins of the nation

4 Connections

- Thinking back to POLS 111 and stories of peoplehood – challenges, strengths, triumphs, common enemies, common goals
- Cites Weber’s discussions of legitimate authority and the impacts of charismatic leadership

5 My Critiques

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